



Skipped the Line, Not the Wait

A Paid Priority Lane and the Delay It Just Moved Onto Everyone Else

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Background

Some primary-school car-pool lines now sell a laminated “priority lane” permit — a marked lane that lets a paying family filter past the general queue at pickup. Despite the permit’s growing uptake, little is known about where the minutes it saves actually come from.

Aims

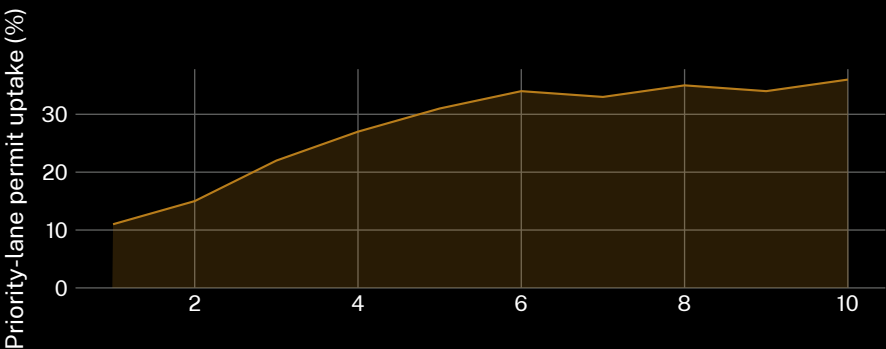
- Test whether priority-lane permit holders leave pickup earlier than general-lane families at the same school
- Measure whether any time a permit saves is time lost by everyone else in the general lane
- Compare complaint patterns at schools with and without a priority lane

Methods

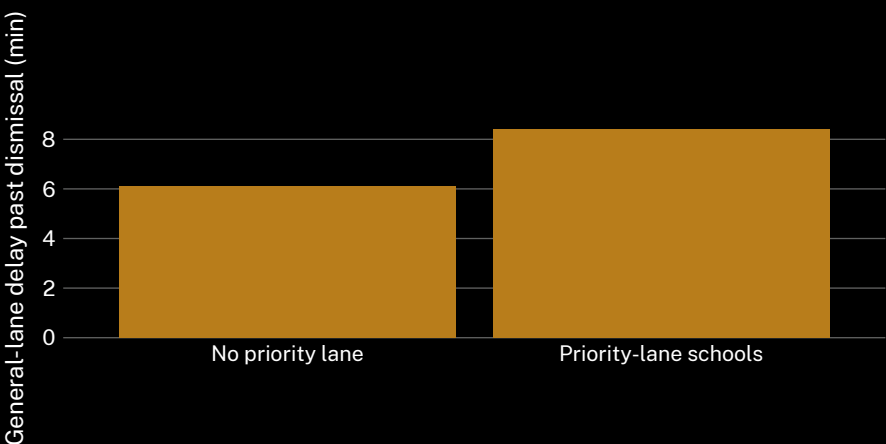
- 214 families · 6 primary schools (3 running a priority lane, 3 without) · kerb timestamp sensor + permit-tag scanner at the gate · 10-week trial
- Linear mixed model of individual departure time on permit status and lane condition, with school-level fixed effects
- Permit price and lane hours fixed for the trial; no mid-trial adjustment

Results

Permit holders left 2.6 minutes earlier on average than general-lane families at the same schools. General-lane departure times at priority-lane schools ran 2.3 minutes slower than the matched no-priority-lane schools — accounting for nearly all of the permit-holders’ saved time.



Priority-lane permit uptake climbed from 11% of car-pool families in week 1 to 34% by week 6, then held between 33% and 36% for the rest of the ten-week trial.



General-lane departure ran 6.1 minutes past scheduled dismissal at schools with no priority lane and 8.4 minutes at the general lane of priority-lane schools — a 2.3-minute gap matching permit-holders’ own saved time almost exactly.

Discussion & conclusions

Permit holders got out sooner; the car-pool line, taken as a whole, did not get any faster — it got slower, by very nearly the amount permit holders gained. Uptake plateaued near a third of families, roughly the share the general lane’s extra 2.3 minutes can be traced to. Complaint volume rose fastest not among general-lane families but among permit holders whose saved minutes narrowed as uptake grew. Next: audit whether permit marketing at any of the six schools describes this as a trade rather than a saving.

References

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We thank the staff of the six participating car-pool lines. School ethics approval SU-2026-114; gate-sensor data pseudonymised at capture; no child identifiers retained beyond the pickup window.

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